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SEALING THE DEAL PM Modi with European Council President António Costa and European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen in New Delhi, Jan. 27

▶ INDIA-EU FTA

INDIA'S BIGGEST TRADE BET

After two decades of talks, India and the European Union conclude their largest-ever free trade pact, reshaping market access, mobility and supply chains on both sides

By M.G. ARUN

IN A SHIFTING GLOBAL TRADE ORDER, India has made its biggest bet yet. After nearly two decades of stop-start talks, India and the European Union—biggest trading partners for each other—finally sealed negotiations on a free trade agreement (FTA) on January 27, the largest deal ever struck by either side. The timing is telling: it comes as trade ties with the US have turned fraught, with Washington slapping steep tariffs on Indian goods and bilateral negotiations showing little urgency.

In 2024-25, India's bilateral trade in goods with the 27-nation EU stood at Rs 11.5 lakh crore, with exports of Rs 6.4 lakh crore and imports of Rs 5.1 lakh crore. Services trade was valued at Rs 7.2 lakh crore in 2024. Together, India and the EU account for 25 per cent of global GDP and a third of world trade. Integration of the two large, diverse and complementary economies will create unprecedented trade and investment opportunities, the government claimed.

The joint announcement was made by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and European Commission president Ursula von der Leyen at the 16th India-EU Summit in New Delhi. Union commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said the deal, coming after 16 rounds of negotiations, was a "statement of deep partnership for the shared prosperity for one-third of humanity".